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Easy Weeknight Dinner Recipes

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Slow Cooker Dinners for Busy Families

By the Trillion Man Outreach kitchen crew Updated October 8, 2026

A slow cooker moves the work of dinner to the one moment when you still have energy: the morning. Five minutes of prep, a lid and a timer, and dinner is waiting when the day falls apart. Here are the rules that make slow cooker meals taste good, five reliable recipes and the safety basics.

Slow cooker rules that actually matter

Use thawed meat.
Frozen meat spends too long in the temperature danger zone. Thaw it in the fridge first.

Keep the lid on.
Each peek can add roughly 20 minutes of cook time.

Fill it half to two-thirds.
Too empty can overcook. Too full may not heat evenly.

Cook to temperature.
Chicken should reach 165 F in the thickest part. See the USDA cooking temperatures
.

Add delicate foods late.
Noodles, dairy, peas and fresh herbs go in near the end.

Use a liner.
It makes cleanup nearly effortless.

Five easy dinners

Salsa chicken (our favorite)

Place 2 lb chicken breasts in the cooker, sprinkle with a packet of taco seasoning, then add a 16 oz jar of salsa and a can of drained black beans. Cook on low 6 to 7 hours or high 3 to 4. Shred and serve in tortillas, over rice or on baked potatoes. The full recipe is on the main page
.

Chicken noodle soup

Combine chicken, chopped carrots, celery, onion, 6 cups broth and seasoning. Cook on low

6 to 8 hours, shred the chicken, then stir in egg noodles for the last 15 to 20 minutes.

Pulled pork sandwiches

A 3 lb pork shoulder with a spice rub and a splash of broth cooks on low 8 to 10 hours until it shreds easily. Pork shoulder needs to cook until tender, well above the minimum safe temperature. Mix with barbecue sauce and pile on buns.

Meatball subs

Combine frozen, fully cooked meatballs and marinara. Cook on low 4 hours. Serve on toasted rolls with mozzarella.

Vegetarian chili

Two cans of beans, diced tomatoes, corn, onion, chili powder and cumin. Cook on low 6 hours. Top with cheese and a spoonful of sour cream.

Turn one batch into three dinners

Cook double and use the extras later. Shredded chicken becomes quesadillas on night two and soup on night three. For more ideas see
leftover chicken recipes
. Many slow cooker meals also freeze well, covered in our
freezer meals guide
.

Budget tip

Slow cookers turn cheaper cuts, such as chicken thighs and pork shoulder, tender. Pair them with rice, beans and frozen vegetables to keep the cost per serving low. See
cheap family dinners with the cost per serving
.

Let us take dinner off your plate

The Rescue Kit picks dinner by how tired you are. The Cheap Dinner Vault shows what each dinner costs.

Get the Rescue Kit

Get the Cheap Dinner Vault

Questions, answered

Can I put frozen chicken in a slow cooker?

It is safest to thaw chicken in the refrigerator first. Frozen meat can stay in the temperature danger zone too long.

How long can leftovers sit after slow cooking?

Refrigerate within 2 hours and use within 3 to 4 days. Reheat to 165 F. Do not use the slow cooker to reheat cold leftovers.

Explore every dinner guide

Keep building your weeknight plan with these related guides. Each one covers a different part of getting dinner on the table.

5-Ingredient Dinners: Short Grocery List, Real Dinner

Simple dinners with five ingredients or fewer.

Cheap Family Dinners With the Cost Per Serving

Learn to estimate cost per serving and stretch a grocery budget.

Easy Dinner Ideas for When You Have No Energy

Low-effort ideas for exhausted nights.

Easy Sheet-Pan Dinners

One-pan dinner formulas, roasting tips and easy combinations.

Freezer Meals for Busy Weeknights

Make-ahead dinner ideas, freezing tips and safe thawing guidance.

Leftover Chicken Recipes

Turn leftover chicken into several easy dinners.

Pantry Staples List for Budget Cooking

Build a practical pantry for affordable meals and less food waste.

Picky-Eater Dinner Ideas That the Whole Table Will Eat

Low-pressure family dinner ideas and practical strategies.

Weekly Meal Plan for Busy Families

A seven-night dinner plan and shopping list.

20 Lazy Dinners for When Your Brain Has Left the Building

Twenty low-effort recipes with prep times and dish counts.

20 Lazy Dinners Sorted by How Tired You Are

Find a dinner that matches your energy level tonight.